Cassadie Mefferd

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Objective: Aspiring graduate student seeking to grow as an educator and naturalist while inspiring stewardship and connection in mountain communities. Driven by a passion for sparking curiosity about nature and science through meaningful outdoor experiences.

Skills: Environmental education | Scientific interpretation | Inquiry-based teaching | Lesson planning | Program facilitation | Systems thinking | Community building | Stakeholder engagement | Emotional intelligence | Creative problem solving | Outdoor leadership | Trip logistics | Risk management | Conflict resolution | Group dynamics | Species identification | Nature journaling | Knot-tying | Backcountry cooking | Orienteering | Photography | Video production | Graphic design | Detail-oriented | Academic research | Data management | Geospatial analysis: Esri ArcGIS Pro, QGIS, RStudio, Python

Education:

Colorado Mountain College (CMC), Steamboat Springs, CO

- **Bachelor of Arts in Sustainability Studies |** *3.94 GPA* | Dean's Honors List **[*December 2026*]**
  - Study Abroad: Bhutan - Environmental Stewardship, Sustainability, & Cultural Immersion [*Fall 2025*]
- **Associate of Arts in Outdoor Education** | *3.93 GPA* | President's Honors List **[*May 2024*]**
  - Study Abroad: Chile - Rivers of Life; Sustainability, Rafting, & Indigenous Culture [*Winter 2023*]

Professional Experience:

Naturalist | *Yampatika* | Steamboat Springs, CO **[*October 2023 - Present*]**

- **Summer Camp Programs:** Facilitated summer camp programs for 300+ children (ages 5-15), applying inclusive instructional strategies to adapt lessons for diverse learning styles.
  - Guided 50 middle and high school students on overnight backpacking trips and instilled wilderness skills, strengthened confidence, and fostered connection. Partners: Rocky Mountain Youth Corps & The Cycle Effect
  - Safely transported students and equipment using a 15-passenger van and gear trailer.
- **School Programs:** Taught a 40-minute beaver ecology lesson during a 9th-grade biology riparian restoration field trip at Warhorse Ranch, reaching 156 Steamboat Springs High School students across twelve rotations over two days. Partners: Friends of the Yampa & Zenobia Consultants.
- **Adult & Community Programs:** Designed and delivered interactive environmental education programs for 88 adults via ski and snowshoe tours, translating complex topics into accessible lessons. Partners: USFS & Steamboat Ski Resort.

Outdoor Program Work Study | *CMC* | Steamboat Springs, CO **[*October 2022 - Present*]**

- Managed maintenance and distribution of technical equipment for multi-day trips while assisting about 250 students annually with gear selection and rentals.
- Developed creative storage and organization solutions to improve efficiency and accessibility in the campus gear room.
- Repurposed retired climbing ropes and gear into upcycled products (doormats, pencil holders, hats) to minimize waste.

Youth Climbing Instructor | *Movement* | Golden, CO **[*January 2022 - 2023*]**

- Taught climbing fundamentals and safety practices through after-school programs, summer camps, and birthday parties.
- Fostered confidence, teamwork, and problem-solving through supportive mentorship.
- Managed risk and supervised climbing sessions for groups of varying skill levels, maintaining a safe, supportive learning environment.

Certifications & Training:

- **Wilderness First Responder (WFR)** | *Desert Mountain Medicine* **[*expires: April 2029*]**
- **Leave No Trace Trainer Course** | *Leave No Trace*
- **Geographic Information Systems (GIS)** | *CMC* **[*expected completion: December 2026*]**
- **Permaculture Design Certificate** | *CMC*
- **Watershed Management Technician** | *U.S. Environmental Protection Agency*
- **Avalanche Level 1** | American Institute for Avalanche Research and Education
- **Swift Water Rescue Training (PRO-I)** | *Swiftwater Safety Institute* **[*expires: April 2027*]**
- **Professional Development Information System (PDIS) Training** | *CO Dept. of Early Childhood*

Note: Certification Documentation and GIS Portfolio are available on my Website

Research & Relevant Projects:

CMC Senior Capstone Project | *Transdisciplinary Research & Practice II (SUS 4900)* **[*Fall 2025 - Spring 2026*]**
Stories Shape Solutions: Balancing Human-Beaver Relationships to Build Resilient Watersheds

- Examined ecological, agricultural, and social dynamics of beaver management in the Upper Yampa Basin through storytelling and transdisciplinary research.
- Conducted 18 semi-structured interviews with ranchers, restoration professionals, educators, water managers, and organizations to evaluate diverse stakeholder perspectives on beaver coexistence.
- Presented findings through an academic paper, poster, and 15-minute presentation at the 2026 CMC Sustainability and Ecosystem Sciences Capstone Conference.
- Created an interpretive booklet called "Beaver Tales," which blends science and storytelling to make complex ecological research fun, free, and accessible to the public.

Community-Based Social Marketing Campaign | *Fostering Sustainable Behavior (SUS 4210)* **[*Spring 2025*]**
CMC's Outdoor Gear Rental Program

- **Promotion & Recruitment:** Increased awareness of gear rental programs to enhance access to the outdoors for college students.
- **Marketing:** Distributed campus-wide posters, social media content, and raffles to lower financial barriers and encourage sustainable gear sharing.

Independent Research Project | *Biology II: Biodiversity and Ecosystems (BIO 1112)* **[*Fall 2024*]**
Effects of Cottonwood Trees (Populus angustifolia) on Yampa River Temperature

- Designed and conducted quantitative research across 11 sites along the Yampa River to evaluate the impact of narrowleaf cottonwood presence on water quality.
- Applied statistical t-tests to analyze differences in water temperature and total dissolved solids.

Campus Involvement & Community Service:

Rock Climbing Club | *President* | CMC **[*August 2022 - May 2026*]**

- Established an inclusive, fun club for students to connect and climb.
- Drove recruitment at campus Club & Activity Fair each semester.
- Partnered with Student Government and local climbing gyms to host free events and a gear raffle through fundraising.

Fall Festival | *Naturalist* | Yampatika **[*September, 2023 - 2026*]**

- Supported event operations by helping staff and partner volunteers set up and tear down booths.
- Delivered crafts, games, and hands-on nature displays to engage the public in local wildlife education.

Farm-to-School Feasibility Meeting | *Activity Facilitator* | ECSD **[*January - June, 2026*]**

- Facilitated a collaborative, systems-thinking online workshop using Lucidchart to engage stakeholders, gather input for a SWOT analysis, and map educational and career pathways.

Re-Tree | *Volunteer* | Western Resilience Center **[*Fall, 2024 - 2026*]**

- Contributed 15 hours to an annual community activity planting native Cottonwood and Alder trees along the Yampa River and tributaries as part of the Yampa River Forest Restoration Project.

Yampa Basin Rendezvous | *Conference Participant* | CW3E, Scripps Institution **[*May, 2024 - 2026*]**

- Participated in multi-day panel discussions and workshops focused on climate resilience, snowpack, and watershed management in the Yampa River Basin.
- Capstone research poster featured during the 2026 networking session, which engaged regional water managers, scientists, and community members.

Yampa River Festival | *Volunteer* | Friends of the Yampa **[*June, 2024 - 2025*]**

- Supported stand-up paddleboard race logistics through precise timekeeping and scouting.
- Participated in the annual packraft race to promote community engagement and regional watershed conservation.

State of the River | *Conference Participant* | Colorado River District **[*March 2026*]**

- Engaged with regional water stakeholders and integrated community research into capstone analysis.

CO Beaver Gathering, Boulder | *Conference Participant* | Beaver Institute **[*October 2025*]**

- Networked with restoration professionals and researchers from across the country to inform independent capstone research on ecological science and social dynamics associated with beaver-based restoration.